THE CALL
Southwest's Leading Weekly

VOL. 81, NO. 33 KANSAS CITY, MO. WEEK OF MARCH 16 TO MARCH 22, 2001

Councilmen Seek To Stop 10 Percent Cut In Budget That Effects Urban Core

By Tracy Allen

The Kansas City Council will vote on a new budget for the 2001-2002 fiscal year, and City Councilmen Troy Nash and Terry Riley are concerned that the budget may not include areas that are necessary for those in the urban core.

The Council will vote on the $943,483,906 budget at the Thursday, March 22, City Council meeting. The budget is an increase of 6.8 percent over the previous years' budget.

What concerns Councilman Nash and Councilman Riley is the proposed reduction of 10 percent in funding for outside agencies that totals $118,680. Those agencies that are considered to lose money are:

- Kansas City Area Economic Development (KCA-EDC), $6,500
- Metropolitan Organization to Counter Sexual Assault (MOCSA), $2,500
- Black Economic Union, $2,337
- Crime Commission, $5,000
- Don Bosco, $6,200
- Guadalupe Center, $6,000
- Homeless shelters, $9,436
- Child care facilities, $67,207
- Wayne Miner Center, $3,500, and
- Black Archives, $10,000.

Although representatives from the agencies have met with the council, word is, that the cuts could still go into effect.

And that worries Nash and Riley, who both serve the Third and Fifth districts which are made up of primarily African Americans and other minorities.

Councilmen Nash and Riley said if the cuts were to pass, it would hurt key entities in the urban core that meets the needs of the poor and the underserved.

"It's like Paul robbing Peter. It is like we have to be lean and mean to trim the budget," said Councilman Riley. "What people need to understand is that for many African Americans and other minorities, government becomes the last resort."

According to Councilman Nash, "Why should we take away from people the last viable opportunity they have to become a part of the mainstream of our country."

"We have a moral obligation to do what is right," Nash continued. "In order to fulfill it, you have to honor that social contract. I'm optimistic that we'll be able to make a decision that will reflect the community."

contract.

"What we want to stress to the Council and to those who want to cut off money supplies is that this is not a black and white issue, this is a people issue," Councilman Nash said. "This is class more than race."

Councilman Riley agreed and said he and Nash will vote against the 10 percent measure.

"This is classism. "We're dealing with poor people who can't take care of themselves. We're dealing with young people who need a place to go. If you cut these programs from them, where are they suppose to go."

That is why Councilmen Nash and Riley are encouraging the community to step forward prior to next Thursday's 3 p.m. Council meeting at City Hall to make their voices heard.

"This is a human issue. We think this budget should reflect diversity and be a budget that meets the needs of everyone in the community," Councilman Riley said.

Budget Amendment

Mayor Kay Barnes suggested amending the current revenue projections by making the fund balance eight percent rather than 8.7 percent, which would free up $1.2 million in resources.

According to Mayor Barnes', that $1.2 million, combined with $700,000 in Council flexibility, should be allocated for Fire department facility improvements and street maintenance, including pothole repair and snow removal.

"The budget effort has been long and arduous, but has met a number of the goals we set as a Council just two years ago," the Mayor said. "We have a structurally balanced budget; we are emphasizing police and fire improvements; and we are making special efforts to improve street maintenance, snow removal and pothole repair; all of which are the most basic issues facing our city."